the boardinghouse to feed the chickens and sweep the coop. In the afternoons, she searched for odd jobs—asking at hotels and inquiring among the women in the laundry for any extra washing or ironing tasks. If she earned a few rutabagas or potatoes, even an old sheet that she and Léa could turn into dresses, she'd find a quiet place to sit and sketch.

The square had an eerie, ghost-like quality. In the two years that had passed since the bombing, nothing had been rebuilt. Where apartments and stores once stood, only stacks of salvageable stones and bricks remained. With nothing to block the view—it was almost like standing in an empty, gray field. Why, she wondered, had André chosen this place for their meeting?

"*Bonjour, Mademoiselle* Rose," a man's voice at her side.

She turned. "André?" He was handsome and young. Her heart tightened.

He nodded. "How are you after yesterday? I was worried about you."

The only people who had ever worried about her were Léa and Maman. "Yes, thank you for—"

"I was lucky to be there. Usually, I avoid the center of town. Too many people."

"Is that why you wanted to meet here?" She motioned to the empty square.

"I hope the rubble doesn't bother you. German soldiers don't patrol here as much. Isn't that good? Let's walk."

"I don't mind the rubble," she said.

As they strolled together, she couldn't help but steal glances at him. The sleeves of his crisp blue shirt were rolled up to his elbows, revealing tanned forearms. His dark hair was cut short, the skin at his collar browned by the sun. Hands tucked in his pockets, he moved with an irresistible lightness, and she wondered how to capture such motion on paper. And then she remembered the sketchbook, and a swell of gratitude rose within her.

"Thank you for bringing my sketchbook to the boardinghouse. How did you know I'd left it on the quai?"

"I'd seen you coming every day that week, drawing the bridge. Since you didn't have your sketchbook when you ran past me, I figured it must be back at the embankment." He angled his head into the sunlight; his black hair softened, and the light turned some of his strands brown. "I hope I